

shoot up in one/one and a half years.

When the chip shortage happened, because I built my own software, I was able to replace the chip with whatever was available and recreate my software for that in, like, a week. We never got impacted by chip shortage. Everybody else... OEMs... got impacted by the chip shortage... We had our share of challenges last year primarily around the front-end of the business—the distribution, because we were doing a new model there as well.

Q: Online...

A: Not online but D2C, which has both online and offline. It is company-owned, direct to customers.

Q: When we spoke last, you said you thought that it (D2C) would be only online. Have you veered towards omni-channel now?

A: People were saying things wouldn't happen without dealerships. My model has proven D2C is better. The cost of distribution is much lower in D2C. Feedback comes directly, I engage with the customers directly. My cost is lower.

Q: So, all your offline stores are yours. There is no dealership.

A: Yes. In a couple months, I'll have 500 stores.

Q: The car, too, won't have dealerships?

A: The same model—D2C, omni-channel. We have partnered with the Tamil Nadu government for acquiring more land—almost 2,000 acres. We are building three factories there—the two-wheeler factory, the car factory, and the cell factory. And it will be the world's largest EV manufacturing site in one location when it is fully completed. Our suppliers are co-locating with us in that area; it will become bigger than any other ecosystem in the world. That's our vision.

Q: In India, every new technology leapfrogs. AI is the next one, right?

A: I will [tell you] what we are doing in AI. In the electric segment, we are working on autonomous vehicles. Applications of AI

ON BUILDING A TECH COMPANY

When you are creating tech, you do your own generational advancements. You are at the cutting edge, so that's how big tech firms are built. They are not built by consuming tech—they are built by creating a road map for the tech, influencing it, and taking the right strategic calls. That's what we are doing

ON OLA ELECTRIC'S STRATEGY

We are focussed on building the three pillars of our strategy. It is building a spectrum of two-wheelers, building cars, and the third pillar has been vertically integrating into cell technology. All three pillars of our strategy are very fast in motion

ON CHARGING STATIONS OR BATTERY SWAPPING

Is it hydrogen or lithium, is it swapping or charging stations, etc.? The anxiety around charging comes from an old mindset. Even with countries where there is high EV adoption, it's not that they have an equal number of charging stations

will be across my businesses. [There are] two things I believe in and you'll see me building my company with those foundational beliefs. One, technologies are accelerating and converging at the same time, which means that electrification is having an accelerated impact than it is expected to have, digitisation is having an accelerated impact, AI will have an accelerated impact. Material technology, space technology, etc., are not only standalone technologies, it's all a convergence. Automotive is a great example of convergence. It includes AI, software, electronics, digitisation, etc. As a firm, we are very technology centric—we started that way. But we did not limit ourselves only to digital technology. We broadened our spectrum significantly: cell technology, energy technology, vehicle & engineering, material science, etc. In the group now, we have around 200 people across the spectrum doing a lot of IP creations for us. That is one core belief on which I'm building my company.

The second belief is that this is India and my generation's destiny is to build a future. What the technology acceleration in India allows us to do is leapfrog, like you said. Also, I believe, the old paradigm of GDP growth of 6-7 per cent will all be changed by technology. If you think of AI, AI can make us so much more productive. If as an ecosystem we adopt AI, GDP growth will be much stronger. The future is of acceleration. India is young, the government is progressive.

Q: There's this view that because you are so obsessed with electric and so much work needs to be done there, you've shifted focus from ride-hailing.

A: Ola is an emerging group and my journey has been slightly different from my other internet peers, in the sense that I didn't sell my company or never focussed on selling... rather, I focussed on building institutions. I'm still in the middle of this journey and people ask me this question [where is my focus?]. This is because we are still in the middle of our journey to establish ourselves as an institutionalised group. But, if you look at our com-